

DISORDERS OF UNCONSCIOUSNESS

There are several types of comas, some of which are described here. Some other disorders also show similarities to comas.

Anoxic brain injury

In anoxia, the brain is starved of oxygen. This leads to confusion, agitation or drowsiness, cyanosis (blue-tinged skin, due to low blood oxygen), and loss of consciousness or coma.

Medically induced coma

A drug-induced coma causes a state of deep unconsciousness, which allows the brain to recover from swelling due to stroke or injury.

Locked-in syndrome

Someone with locked-in syndrome is conscious, but brain damage has caused almost complete paralysis. The person almost always communicates using eye movements.

Vegetative state

A person in a vegetative state does not show any meaningful emotional responses, follow objects with their eyes, or respond to voices. Recovery is usually highly unlikely.

Coma

A coma is a prolonged state of deep unconsciousness, whether due to injury or induced to treat a medical condition. Coma patients are unresponsive and may look like they are asleep. Unlike in deep sleep, however, a person in a coma cannot be awakened by any stimulation, including pain.

Comas are caused mainly by head injuries that damage the brain. They often result in swelling, which in turn leads to increased pressure on the brain and damages the reticular activating system—that part of the brain responsible for arousal and awareness.

Bleeding in the brain, a loss of oxygen, infections, an overdose, chemical imbalances, or a buildup of toxins can also trigger a coma, as can the side effects of various conditions. A temporary and reversible coma occurs in diabetes,

for example, when blood-sugar levels remain either extremely high or far too low. More than 50 percent of comas are related to head traumas or disturbances in the brain's circulatory system.

Treatment

The treatment for coma depends on the specific cause but in general involves supportive measures. Coma patients are placed in an intensive care unit and may often require full life support until their situation improves.

Depression

More than simply feeling unhappy, depression consists of persistent feelings of sadness, hopelessness, and apathy, accompanied by sleep disorders, fatigue, and appetite changes.

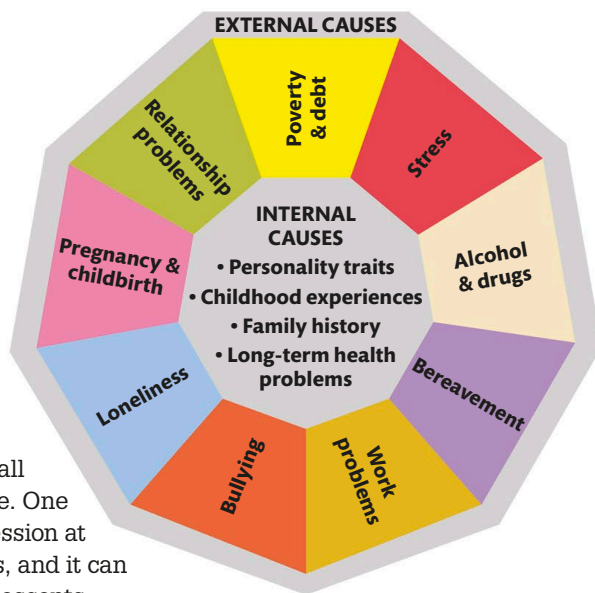
Depression acts on people in different ways and to varying degrees. Symptoms can be mild to severe—the latter is sometimes referred to as “clinical depression”—and range from constantly feeling unhappy, tearfulness, and a loss of interest in normal activities to an inability to perform daily tasks and thoughts of suicide.

Physical symptoms

Depression and anxiety often go hand in hand. The disorder may also bring about physical symptoms, such as persistent

fatigue, insomnia or excessive sleeping, weight loss or gain, loss of sex drive, and physical pain.

Although it has multiple causes, depression is a genuine illness that can impact all aspects of a person's life. One in 10 people have depression at some point in their lives, and it can affect children and adolescents. Depending on its severity, treatment may include medication and psychotherapy.



Causes of depression

Stressful life events can act as external triggers for depression. These interact with internal causes that include a family history.